

II4 Ezra

The priest and scribe who set his heart to study God's Law, live it and teach it to a people starting over.

Ezra was a priest descended from Aaron and a scholar of the Law of Moses. In 458 BC the Persian king Artaxerxes sent him from Babylon to Jerusalem with gifts for the temple and a commission to teach God's Law. He led a second group of exiles home, trusting God rather than soldiers. Finding that many had married into the surrounding peoples and their worship, he confessed the nation's sin as his own and led a painful reform. Later he read the Law aloud while the Levites helped the people understand. His life shows the power of God's Word taken seriously.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Ezra</i> , "help"
Family	A priest, "the son of Seraiah," descended from Aaron (Ezra 7:1–5)
Role	"A ready scribe in the law of Moses" (Ezra 7:6)
Came to Jerusalem	c. 458 BC, the seventh year of Artaxerxes I (Ezra 7:7–8)
Key people	Artaxerxes, Shechaniah, the Levites, Nehemiah
Main passages	Ezra 7–10; Nehemiah 8; 12:26, 36
Tradition	Jewish tradition credits him with gathering the Scriptures
New Testament	Not named

"For Ezra had prepared his heart to seek the law of the LORD, and to do it, and to teach in Israel statutes and judgments."

Ezra 7:10, KJV

The life of Ezra

Dates approximate (BC). Most date Ezra's arrival to 458 BC (Artaxerxes I); some prefer 398 BC, after Nehemiah. The text presents them working together (Nehemiah 8:9).

- c. 458 BC

7th year of Artaxerxes

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Sent by the king

Artaxerxes grants Ezra silver, gold and supplies, and power to appoint judges and teach the Law. *Ezra 7:6, 11-26*
- c. 458 BC

1st month

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Fasting by the river Ahava

Ezra sends for Levites and, ashamed to ask the king for soldiers, proclaims a fast for protection. *Ezra 8:15-23*
- c. 458 BC

5th month

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Safe arrival

The company reaches Jerusalem unharmed, for "the hand of our God was upon us." *Ezra 7:8-9; 8:31-36*
- c. 458-457 BC

Soon after

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Grief and reform

Told of mixed marriages, Ezra tears his garments and prays. The people gather in heavy rain, and the cases are examined. *Ezra 9:1-10:44*
- c. 445/444 BC

7th month

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Reading the Law

Ezra reads the Book from morning to midday, and the people keep the Feast of Tabernacles with joy. *Nehemiah 8:1-18*
- Later

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At the dedication of the wall

"Ezra the scribe" goes before one of the two great companies on the walls. *Nehemiah 12:26, 31-43*

Group notes

Key activities

Ezra's reform in chapter 10 is hard for many modern readers. The Law forbade such marriages because they would turn Israel to other gods (Deuteronomy 7:3–4). Christians differ on how it applies today. Paul tells a believer not to leave an unbelieving spouse who is willing to stay (1 Corinthians 7:12–14).

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- I Set his heart on God's Word.** He prepared himself to seek the Law, to do it and to teach it, in that order. *Ezra 7:10*

 - 2 Gave God the credit.** He praised God for putting it in the king's heart to beautify the temple. *Ezra 7:27–28*

 - 3 Recruited Levites.** He would not set out until Levites and temple servants had joined the group. *Ezra 8:15–20*

 - 4 Trusted God for protection.** He had told the king, "The hand of our God is upon all them for good that seek him," so he fasted instead of asking for soldiers. *Ezra 8:21–23*

 - 5 Handled money with care.** He weighed the treasure into the priests' hands and had it weighed and recorded again in Jerusalem. *Ezra 8:24–34*

 - 6 Grieved over sin.** He tore his clothes and sat "astounded" until the evening sacrifice. *Ezra 9:3–4*

 - 7 Confessed as one of the people.** He prayed, "O my God, I am ashamed and blush to lift up my face to thee." *Ezra 9:5–15*

 - 8 Led a hard reform.** Urged by Shechaniah, he called the people to confess and separate from the marriages. *Ezra 10:1–17*

 - 9 Read the Law aloud.** Standing on "a pulpit of wood," he opened the Book, and all the people stood. *Nehemiah 8:1–6*

 - 10 Made the Word clear.** He and the Levites "read in the book in the law of God distinctly, and gave the sense." *Nehemiah 8:7–8*

 - II Restored a forgotten feast.** He read the Law every day of the Feast of Tabernacles, kept as it had not been since Joshua. *Nehemiah 8:13–18*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Ezra. Jewish tradition credits him with fixing the Scriptures and writing Chronicles; 1 and 2 Esdras (Apocrypha) bear his name.

Old Testament

Ezra 7–10	His own account, much of it in the first person
Nehemiah 8:1–18	Reads the Law and leads the Feast of Tabernacles
Nehemiah 12:26, 36	Named with Nehemiah; leads a procession on the wall
Nehemiah 12:1, 13	An earlier priest Ezra, a different man
Echo: Deuteronomy 31:10–12; 2 Kings 23:1–3	The Law read to all the people

New Testament

Echo: Luke 4:16–21; 24:27	Jesus reads and opens the Scriptures
Echo: James 1:22	"Be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three things did Ezra set his heart to do (Ezra 7:10)?
2. *Understand:* Why did the people weep at the Law, and why were they told to rejoice (Nehemiah 8:9–12)?
3. *Apply:* Ezra studied, obeyed, then taught. Which do you most need to grow in this week?
4. *Apply:* Ezra trusted God rather than soldiers. Where do you need to trust God over your own safety nets?